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Catherine Russell

Catherine Russell has enjoyed an active career as a jazz and pop vocalist. She has provided background vocals for a lengthy list of notable recording artists, including David Bowie, Paul Simon, Steely Dan, and James Taylor. Catherine has made the transition to a leader of her own group and has headlined at major jazz venues both here and abroad.

Catherine was interviewed on October 26, 2018 in Utica, NY by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Catherine Russell with me today in Utica, before a gig at Hamilton College. Welcome.

CR: Thank you.

MR: When you were a kid, can you recall when you learned what the word "gig" meant?

CR: Probably when my mother, you know, because my parents were — well my dad was home a lot at that point. That was towards the end of his life. But my mother didn't stop working. So people would call the house and call her for work and she'd go to work. She'd take her bass and she'd go to work, or she was also a concert choral singer so she would go to choral rehearsals. So I would know that that was where she was going. That's what she did.

MR: And was there was a point where, in talking to your friends, that you discovered that what your mom did was a little different?

CR: Yeah because they'd say, "Oh what do your parents do?" I said, "Well they're musicians." And people would say, "Oh, okay." Because people didn't think that was a real source of income. That wasn't real work. So they went to work at night. They didn't go to work in the daytime like everybody else. And so you know I didn't really talk about Louis Armstrong for a long time, because people didn't believe that my father — oh if you say, "Oh I was at Louis Armstrong's house last night." "Yeah, sure. Sure you were." So yeah. So that's kind of, you know and then my mother got me involved as a dancer first. So my mother got me involved in dance. And then I started working with the Katherine Dunham Company when I was seven, but I was dancing from when I was five years old. So I kind of grew up differently than, you know, my little friends.

MR: And then you went to a drama academy, also?

CR: That was much later. That was at the college level. I went to the American Academy of Dramatic Arts.

MR: So the idea of being in front of an audience was, you got that at an early age and got fairly comfortable with it?

CR: I would say pre-pubescent life I was very comfortable in front of an audience. I didn't think about it. I just remember being at the Metropolitan Opera House because when we did "Aida," which was what I did with the Katherine Dunham Dance Company, we did that for four seasons from 1963 to 1967. So we were at the old Metropolitan Opera House for two seasons. They tore that down, they built Lincoln Center then we moved in to the new Metropolitan Opera House for two seasons. So I think we were at the old Met. And it was me and another kid. So it was like six dancers. So we were the youngest ones, then there were middle dancers that might have been eleven or twelve years old. We were like seven, eight years old. And then there were the older ones. So there were six female dancers that would do a dance in part of the second act of "Aida." So we were African, you know, it was an African dance troupe. And I just remember sitting there before the show started, and going, oh, it's a full house — thinking to myself, there's a lot of people here. So we were sitting at the Queen Amneris was the character, and it was Leontyne Price. So we were sitting at the feet of Leontyne Price. And she said, "Hello" you know, and she was all dressed up in her Egyptian, or whatever it was. And it didn't bother me a bit. Later on though, when puberty hit, I thought oh I'm not pretty, I'm not this, I'm not that, so then I started to get very nervous.

MR: The innocence of youth, right? Like you didn't know that this should be nerve wracking.

CR: Yeah. I just wasn't into a comparison of me and other girls and anything like that. I just said wow, this is a really cool job. You know it's a job. We were working.

MR: And did they pay you?

CR: Yeah. They paid us five dollars a performance.

MR: Your first gig. Five dollars.

CR: Five dollars.

MR: That was one dollar more than I made on my first gig. And it wasn't at Lincoln Center.

CR: You know it sounds funny. Five dollars actually bought something in those days.

MR: That's right. Was music something that your mother felt okay with you going into?

CR: Yeah. She — well I played violin — you know when music was in schools it was a mandatory thing so you had band, so I played violin. Then I went to — I tried to play everything in the orchestra. So I tried to play the trumpet. Couldn't do that. Couldn't get a sound out of the trumpet. I tried saxophone but I didn't like the vibration on my lower lip and I just couldn't understand the reeds and that kind of thing. So I went to drums and percussion. First I went to tuba. Because my grandfather played tuba and sousaphone. So tuba was great because the embouchure was loose. I was the bass in the ensemble, like my mom, and I could hide in it. I could wear it. I could get in it. You know it was a big, nice thing. So I really enjoyed that. And I used to, when I started working jobs, because at one point my mother said, "Well you are going to go out of the house and get a job.

Now. Here's a newspaper and you will find a job." And I said, "What?" And she said, "No, you're going to find a job and you're going to pay half the rent." So I did that. So I'd come home and say, "Oh, mom, I got a job as a receptionist at Silverstein Properties." And Silverstein, that was a big company in New York. And she'd say, all right, good. That's good. And then I'd come home and say, "You know I got a gig. We're going to play at — " such-and-such club. She'd go, "Great, great, I'm coming. I'm bringing — " you know. So it was kind of like that. She was very more excited about the gigs than regular day work.

MR: And often times you might make on a gig what it would take you a day to make —

CR: Oh, a week basically. That was the difference. So music always paid better.

MR: And your grandfather played with James Reese, is that right?

CR: James Reese Europe. Yeah.

MR: So you have a lineage —

CR: And he also went to Juilliard School. So that's why my mom wanted to go there.

MR: So your dad passed away, you were seven. So I'm curious if you have this process of discovery about him going on now.

CR: Yeah. I mean I remember him then because my memory was that — one of them was that he would practice. Sit at a piano and practice classical music. And then the other one, the other two is that he was always dressed up in the house. He never walked around the house in a bathrobe or slippers or pajamas. He was always dressed up. Pants creased. He used to send his shirts to the Chinese laundry, get them back in that paper in the box. And his last job was as a chauffeur for the president of Yeshiva University in upper Manhattan, in Washington Heights. So I remembered that. And then he liked his home movies. So he had a Bell & Howell, you know, metal set up with the reels and a projector and a splicing machine. So he'd sit and splice. So we have a lot of footage of me. He'd sit and — he took a lot of the family you know — so he'd sit and splice. He'd be sitting there for hours with the razor blade and the scotch tape and he's editing and splicing you know. And that's where we got our footage of Louis Armstrong as well. So I remember that. I remember his friends, he had friends and I had a very kind of Panamanian/ Caribbean upbringing, so it was always good food, cooking and he was a good cook, or we'd spend time with relatives, our Panamanian family. But now, yeah. I mean, and then I remember then listening to his music also. So that was some of the first music I ever heard besides classical music, because my mother was very much into classical music and opera. And I thought wow, this sounds great. It sounds like fun. These people sing. I could kind of see the musicians in my mind or something. I imagined people just dancing to this music. But yeah, and so now, going back through his archive and everything, is very exciting. All the — because he was really in the thick of so much stuff back then.

MR: The first time you saw, there's some footage of him performing.

CR: Yeah. Not that much, some.

MR: Right. Was that an odd experience? The first time you saw that?

CR: Not odd. I mean it was great. I mean I was working with a singer named Carrie Smith who my mother got me a job with, this was in the early 80s. And she was a Gospel jazz singer who worked a lot in Europe, you know, worked a lot with big bands and different ensembles, traveled overseas quite a bit. So she wanted to replace one of the singers that was working with her. I think she must have known, she was from Newark — not from Newark but she had resided in Newark for a long time. So I think one of these singers might have been from the church that she attended or something like that. She was not happy with that person. So she asked my mother, well who can I get. And my mother said, "Well my daughter sings." And my passport was in order so I went. So there was a doctor in France, one of these very wealthy gentlemen who would host jazz musicians. So that was a regular thing in Europe. You know you'd go over there and you'd go to somebody's house all day long, and they feed you and they host you and he was also an archivist of soundies. So he said one day, "Would you like to see your father? Would you like to see your father?" I said, "Sure." So then he brought out the soundie and I finally saw him with the band, all dressed up you know. I said yeah. Smiling. I said, "Yeah, that's daddy." You know? So it was cool. So we sat and watched a few of those soundies and, you know it wasn't odd, it was great.

MR: Okay. I have a small story about that because I used to be in a band, basically a progressive rock band, and when my kids, we had some footage of it, and when we put it on for them, they didn't want to watch it.

CR: Wow.

MR: I think it was just, "Dad, what are you doing?" So I wondered if it was the same for you.

CR: Well kids I guess don't think their folks are human beings. Don't think we were ever young or something. So it's weird to them. They don't want to think that about us. But I actually, you know, I am still excited — like when I see — somebody sent me footage of my mother recently, playing with Max Roach or something like that. And I didn't know she played with Max Roach. You know, so it was like of course she played with — she played with everybody. So I really liked seeing them as people.

MR: Did she talk about travails of being on the road?

CR: Sure.

MR: Like what kind of things might she have shared with you?

CR: Well when she was with the International Sweethearts of Rhythm in the 40s, which was, there were several, probably many all-female bands and orchestras back then during World War II when all the men went overseas. But this orchestra started from a school,

from the Piney Woods School down south. And they really groomed their girls. And it was like the first interracial, multi-cultural female big band. And I'm not sure if there were others that were interracial. So when she came out of Juilliard she joined them for about a year and a half or so, and she would talk about traveling down south, which, the more biographies that I read of black artists in all genres, that was a, traveling down south you just didn't know if you were going to make it — to the end of that day or the next day, you couldn't eat anywhere, you couldn't go anywhere, you had to stay — I think they traveled, they might have traveled in a bus, and I'm not sure about that, but they would send maybe the lightest skinned members in, if they stopped for food, they would send the ones in that could pass for white because they wouldn't serve black people. And if they did serve you they'd break the plates afterwards because they figured white folks are not going to eat on these plates if they knew black people had eaten on them. So and also they used to have ropes down the middle of the dance floor. Or they'd have whites in the orchestra and blacks in the balcony type of thing. So if people were dancing, and they would — started to mix, and the races started to mix, Mom told me that they'd have bomb scares, they'd have a reason why the cops would come and clear out the place. You know? So it was literally you did not know — a lot of bands had white drivers so they wouldn't get stopped, so they wouldn't get pulled over. You had to leave town before dark, like immediately. You couldn't stay anywhere. So there was kind of like an underground railroad system of Miss Lulu's is expecting certain bands that are going to come through town and so they'd have a place to stay and a place to eat. But you couldn't go anywhere. You couldn't walk down the street. You couldn't — it wasn't, especially women. Also they had a list of rules I've just remembered for the Sweethearts that you could do this but you — like all of these rules for the women, for the girls. You couldn't talk to men, you couldn't do any — you know you had to stay with the group, you couldn't — there were all these — we have that actually, and I wish I had brought it with me because it's really, they were very well trained young ladies.

MR: Did she say if they had a man traveling with them, like a manager, or was the manager a woman?

CR: I think the manager was a man but they had chaperones. They would have female chaperones.

MR: Yeah. That must have made them pretty strong women I would think.

CR: Yeah. You know the thing about that is also that women were only supposed to play violin and piano and sing. They weren't supposed to play the horn. Men didn't want to see a horn in a woman's mouth type of thing. So if you — or a bass, or something that was not considered a feminine type of a thing. So trumpet players and saxophone players, trombone players, you had to be strong enough to take all the criticism that went along

with that, from men and from other women. Why would you be playing that, you know what I mean? So some women lasted longer than others. Some lasted a few months or a year or something and then decided eh, I don't want to do this, I want to have babies, I want to get married, I don't want to do this anymore. And some had their families and continued to work as musicians. But still, when the war ended and the men came home a lot of them lost their gigs anyway, so it was like go back in the kitchen you know, where you belong.

MR: Now that was over 70 years ago. Do you think the women in jazz in 2018 has changed that much?

CR: Yeah I do.

MR: Okay.

CR: Because women, in America at least, I mean we have a choice about what we want to do with out lives, and we're not made to feel incomplete or anything like that you know what I mean, if we choose to continue to work instead of having children or whatever you know what I mean? So many of my female colleagues don't — chose to work and to keep working and not take twenty years off to raise children. Because it's one or the other in a lot of cases you know. So yeah, so I think that women are more respected as equals, as good musicians these days. But then, a lot of men still would prefer to work with other men. So I think it's both.

MR: You and I are similar in age, and I was a buyer of 45 RPMs and I wondered if that was the medium that you would have —

CR: Oh yeah. I remember the first 45 I ever bought, which was by the Supremes, and I think it was "Can't Hurry Love." And it cost forty-seven cents. And I was staying with my grandparents in Harlem, cause my mother was working so I used to stay with relatives. And there was a little record store down the street from them on 130th and Amsterdam, and that was my first 45 and I still have it.

MR: All right. Do you recall zoning in on certain parts of the music, rather than the whole thing. Like the back-up vocals, the bass line?

CR: Bass lines, which is why I love swing music so much, because the bass moves. It makes you, I like anything — I like to move you know. I like that, I liked Motown, because of those bass lines — those great James Jamerson bass lines. I used to wonder, when I used to watch, I used to watch a lot of variety shows growing up. I don't know if you did the same. So I was hooked on, we'd — my mother had a radio in the kitchen so we'd listen to everything from Arthur Godfrey Hour to William B. Williams who was a DJ in New York who had, he would play what is now known as the Great American Songbook. But his program was called Make Believe Ballroom. And so we'd listen to those. And then you were able to see everybody on T.V. at night. So if you heard Frank Sinatra in the

morning, or Tony Bennett or Dean Martin, Ella Fitzgerald, then maybe they'd be on somebody's program at night. So it was really exciting to me. Then of course we'd watch a lot of Ed Sullivan, you know, on Sunday nights. And I would wonder sometimes like now I know why, but I would wonder okay you saw the group but then there was all this arrangement happening. Where are the other people? Where are the strings at? I hear strings. I hear horns. You know? And all I'm seeing is four guys or whatever, singing, with nothing there. It's like I used to think okay, where is the orchestra? Is it the house orchestra or are their other people? So this is what I used to wonder.

MR: Me too. Did a time come when you, in your career, you had to lip sync for videos and stuff?

CR: Yeah. Mainly I worked with Cyndi Lauper, I worked in her band for four years in the 90s. And we would do a lot of promotional stuff. So when we did the promotional stuff it was, she'd have all females and I was the drummer. I was the fake drummer. So, and they'd put a little mic there you know, so you'd have these dummy drums that don't, they're muted. So you can beat them to death and they don't sound like anything. And I can do this, but I can't play four — so they'd have me cut off here.

MR: Yeah. Don't get a picture of her feet.

CR: So yeah. That was when I would lip sync. Not on my own as a solo artist or anything like that. You know we usually — I worked in France with a group called New Paradise. It was a vocal group. And the other two girls, this was in 1980, '81. So the other two girls spoke no English, they were French, and they would lip sync phonetically in English, but I was the one that sang. So we'd usually sing the tracks you know. So that wasn't actual lip syncing, you know but they were lip syncing. But lip syncing is hard.

MR: To make it look real?

CR: Yeah. You have to remember what you did.

MR: The physical act, really, and to just move your mouth.

CR: So you usually, you know, in that case you'd sing along with it, so you're breathing. Otherwise you're not breathing.

MR: Okay. You have a very lengthy list of people you've collaborated with vocally, and do you know, if you go to a studio, you get called in to do a vocal overdub, how much do you know about what you're going to face before you get there, usually?

CR: Well it depends. Sometimes people will send you the tune before you get there so at least you can hear it. And it depends on if it's a lead vocal or if it's a back-up vocal. And generally they want, somehow they want you to invent things on the spot. So it's usually, I started learning to say, "What are your ideas." Because I'm getting one fee and that's not as a writer. So whatever your ideas are, we're going to start with yours. Because they're usually like, "And if you hear anything — if you hear anything." So you know

that's what I normally do. Let's put your ideas down. Whatever you've got, we'll start with those, and if there's something else we want to add then I can do that.

MR: Well our mutual friend Tom McGrath said that you're very good at that. He remembers, he says, the stacking harmonies. He says wow.

CR: I like doing that. That's fun.

MR: When you say you get paid the same fee, if you're in there for five hours when it was supposed to be two —

CR: Well no, then it's usually if it's two and it gets to an hour and 59 minutes then we're going to talk about what we can do about that.

MR: The mic doesn't work after two hours.

CR: Then we're going to say, well then you get into, you learn not to get paid by the hour, you know. There's no hourly rate. We set a rate and we stick to that within the timeframe that we set up. So it's that and then if it goes over that then we have to talk about something else. You learn the hard way, you know what I mean?

MR: Have I ever heard your voice on commercials?

CR: Yes, yes. Most recently UPS. We had a UPS commercial that ran, it actually might still be running a little bit, but yeah, they had a big campaign. So I did that. And what was the song? Oh, "I Ain't Got Nobody." And then I've done a Honey Nut Cheerios, I did a Plantar's Peanut that ran, these were all lead jingles. So I've done a ton that were just back-up group stuff. I had one, that Plantar's Peanut was good because it ran during the Super Bowl. So that was nice. And Staples, yeah, we had the Staples ad that ran during the holidays. "Have Yourself a Merry Little Christmas" which was really very nice, helped me buy some nice Christmas presents.

MR: Musicians like the Super Bowl.

CR: Yes.

MR: And Bucky Pizzarelli said the same thing. He got this big check and, "What's this for?"

CR: Yes. That thing runs a lot. It's great.

MR: So you get a contract that stipulates something about how many, oh what am I trying to say, how long does it last? How many years?

CR: There's a maximum period of use, which is on the pay stub when you get it. So you know how long it's going to — after which — they sometimes they extend them, which is nice. Then you go, "Oh I got another year, that's great." And then after that maximum period of use you can pretty much know that it's over you know.

MR: I recently watched a documentary I think called "Twenty Feet From Stardom." Do all — I suppose I know the answer to this already. Do all or most back-up singers aspire to move up to the front of the stage?

CR: No. Because it's two different sets of skills. So I work with many colleagues who, some of whom have had solo careers, and some have not. And we are very happy backing up whomever we, whatever iconic individuals we get to back up. It's an honor. It's a privilege, it's a great job. You learn all the time. You have to aspire to sing in tune, work with other people, it's a team effort. You have to move together. And you're part of a big thing that — people are very happy in the audience you know what I mean? It's a — you know, so I work with people who have worked with Bryan Ferry over many years, Luther Vandross, Aretha Franklin. Many of us have done a lot of TV work behind many people, Paul Simon, Youssou N'Dour, Snoop Dogg, you know, Al Green, I mean you name 'em. And Don Henley, all kinds of people. And that's fun. I mean it's really, really fun. And these are the people that I learned how to sing back-up from, because we were in the studios for many, many years doing many recordings. And it's a skill. How to blend with the vocalist. I did an album for Suzanne Vega several years ago, and her voice and my voice could not be different. Our voices could not be more different. But we blended. The great thing is that I went in and our voices blended. It was great to be able to sing with her. To make my voice do something else. You know? So it's a skill. You know? And also, when you're the band leader, you have to make all the decisions. Your name is on the ticket you know. I can't look around and say, "What do you think?" It's up to me. And so some people would rather not be bothered with that. They're doing just fine you know. They've bought homes, they've raised families, they've done just fine as back-up and chorus singers. And so the thing — I'm glad they made the film, and Lisa Fischer, who starred in the film is a very good friend of mine, very dear friend who is doing very well now as a solo artist. She was a solo artist before, and as a result of the film now has a solo career. But she backed up the Rolling Stones for years. And that was a great job for her you know. Sting. I mean, you know. And she's a phenomenal artist. She's a phenomenal vocalist and a wonderful human being. And what was good about the film is that they highlighted the fact that she had a solo career and then they stopped taking her calls and all of a sudden — and she said you know what? I just want to work. I want to work. And that's how I feel, that's how many of our colleagues feel. Unfortunately the film focused on people that were unhappy in the background. And I wish that there would be a sequel to that film of those of us that are very happy doing what we do.

MR: Well said. Because I did get that impression, like that they all didn't quite feel like they made it.

CR: Yes. And unfortunately it focused on artists who got marginalized in whatever major record label they were with, and then did not go the way they wanted to go. But that just focused on a few people and not all the other people who were in scenes in that film who are my colleagues, who are very happy — we do a lot — we still do work together you

know. So unfortunately they did not interview those people. And I would hope that either the same gentleman or someone else would make another — a sequel, and interview some more of us that have done very nicely and are happy in that role.

MR: Well we're doing that right now.

CR: We're doing that right now.

MR: So you wanted to be — I mean you aspired to go beyond that? Or did it just sort of happen?

CR: No I mean I wanted to work. So probably in my early twenties I think, when I was starting to audition for shows and things like that in New York. I didn't know what I wanted to do. I just knew, all right I had some Gospel. I was raised Presbyterian so I was not raised in the Baptist church, but I loved Gospel music. So I moved out to the west coast when I was in my teens, and one thing led to another and I was able to join a Gospel choir led by the great Reverend Daryl Coley, who was a star in the Gospel music industry, a Stellar Award winner. And he was working along with — he had his own group which was the New Generation Singers, which was the group I joined. And I'm talking about the Bay Area now, in Oakland, in the mid-seventies. And he worked along with the Hawkins family, who were a big pioneering family, a Gospel group of the contemporary Gospel field, not the traditional field. And so that's kind of where I found my voice you know, and I said, "Oh okay. Maybe my voice is a little bigger than I think it is, or maybe." So he was the one that really pushed me to get out front. Because I was very content in the choir, in the alto section of the choir. And he just said, "No, today" you know, not today, but, "the next performance we do you're going to lead a song." And I said, "Why?" "Because I want you to sing this. I think you can sing this." So that was really my first experience singing with all these voices behind me and having to really get my voice out there. So then after that I said well maybe I should try — I moved back to New York and went to acting school and said maybe I should try to audition. You know, I don't know if I'm going to get a job but maybe I should try to do that. So then I was sitting at an audition one day — these are long answers to short questions I hope that's okay — and one of the other girls came in. She said, "Annie Lennox called me on the phone." I said — I thought, how do you get Annie Lennox? How does that happen? So I filed that away and I said that's what I want to do. I want to tour. I want to travel, and I want to be able to say that some day. So-and-so called me on the phone. I'll never forget it, when she walked in and I'm waiting, the three of us are sitting there waiting to audition. And I thought how does — okay, that's it, that's my mission. So then after that, you know this and that happened, I start doing demos for people, and Tom McGrath was one of those people, like he started calling, the New York network type thing. And then I started working for Robert Klein, comedian Robert Klein when he had a little music in

his shows so he started doing HBO shows, so I was called to do that as a result of doing demos for Bob Stein, who is his musical director. So like all these things kind of started happening and then I started sitting in in bands in New York. And then I was doing weddings at the same time, meeting people, just meeting people. I said I don't know what I'm doing but I'm just going to try to meet as many people as I can. So then I started singing at Catch a Rising Star comedy club in between comedians, many of whom you know, including like Joy Behar, Susie Essman, all these people who used to — we all had 15 minute slots and the singer would — usually they'd put the singer on after somebody famous because other comics didn't want to follow that person. Like if Robin Williams or Eddie Murphy came in then one of us would go on after them because nobody wanted to follow them type of thing. Then they had a little trio that used to play the comics on and off. [Scats] Right? So the drummer of that trio was playing in another band, said, "Why don't you come up here. I think that — I work in a band, I think they would like you up here." So it turns out that that was the band that turned into the back-up band for Donald Fagen, that started doing the New York Nights shows in New York which then turned into the reformation of Steely Dan touring. So then that's how I got to have people call me on the phone. So in those days you had cassettes in the answering machine. So every time somebody famous called me I would keep the cassette. So you know I have: "Hi Catherine, this is Donald Fagen." So after that I pull that tape out and keep that. And then, "Hi Catherine, this is Paul Simon." So I have that someplace. So you know, so eventually I didn't know how I was going to get there but eventually I got there.

MR: That's terrific. It's very refreshing that that is special to you.

CR: Of course.

MR: Because people get jaded, you know I think, how could you, right? But some people do. So now you're in a position, when you do your solo gigs like tonight, you're the leader. I want to talk about accompanists for a minute. For you what makes a good accompanist?

CR: A person that listens and breathes along with you, breathes along with the singer so that we are one. So I would say through — going through a series of musicians to find people who were into swing and blues and the kind of stuff that I like to do, I found artists that are aligned, that we feel the same way. Our pocket is the same. We swing the same. We play the blues the same. So that's what I look for is just alignment in thinking. And people that leave space. Because I have experienced working with guitar players, I mean throughout the years of jamming in clubs and things like that when they, "Catherine come up and sing these blues." So I'd get up and sing something and the guys don't leave me any space. So there was one night I remember where he's a nice person, sweet, I still know him today, but I wouldn't finish a phrase and he'd be [scats]. And so I just put the mic down. I said — obviously you have more to say than I do.

MR: He was being musically rude.

CR: Well he didn't know. You know, he didn't know. And it wasn't my gig. I didn't call him for the gig it was just a bunch of us who were jamming. So you go through a lot of different situations with different musicians to find the people who you are aligned with the most.

MR: Do you ever sort of like someone but they're doing something that you think you can change them some? Is it worth the potential?

CR: That's tough you know. Some people take constructive — it's not criticism, but can we do it like this. Some people take that personally. Like, "I'm not doing — why? Aren't I don't a good job?" type of thing. So it depends. If I want to go through that with the person, because the other 99 percent of what they're doing is great, then I'll try to do that. I'll try to work and say, "Can we arrive at this?" It depends. So as I say, if the other 99 percent of what they're doing is working for me then I will try to mold that and get it to where I want it or I'll drop it and deal with somebody else.

MR: Early on when you were making that transition, did you find that it was necessary to somehow let the accompanist, the band members, know that you know music? That you're not a singer that was born with this great voice but doesn't know about keys and doesn't know about going to the bridge and all that. I mean I'm not sure I'm asking the question right. But have you felt like I have to let these players know that I'm informed.

CR: It happens once in a while. So I would say when I was — no because this is like a two part answer. When I was working at the comedy club, Catch a Rising Star, I would have to come in and I'd sing three songs. So I was the one that brought them the charts. So if there was — so I'd write them up. You know I'd just write them up and give them to them and they would play them down and there was no question because I'd just say, "Here — okay no I meant a D minor there" or whatever. So people always know that I know what I want. I have had, though, because in the early days I didn't have arrangers to work with because I wasn't at that stage yet. So when I finally got to the stage where I needed arrangements, people were calling me and it was like, "I don't have arrangements." How do you get arrangements? You call an arranger and you pay them to arrange something for you. So there was one instance where the person, I had given that person the chord chart of the changes that I wanted and they decided not to do something that I wanted them to do, and held up my recording session saying — and I said, "No, at the end of the bridge there's another chord there, that's what I want." And he said, "Well you send me the charts and I do what I want anyway." I said, "Oh really? Okay I want that chord right there. So I'm going to wait until we get that chord in there because that's what I want." So I had to hold — I'm paying for everything and I had to hold up my session and he did his little bravado thing, and I just thought okay I'll file that away. He's

a fabulous arranger, I love what he does, but that was just one instance of having to stand up for myself and saying, "No, that's what I want." And he knows I know what I want but he was just exercising his — he figured I'll put my own stamp on this. But I said no I'm putting my stamp on it because it's — my name is on the record.

MR: It was with multiple horns?

CR: Yeah.

MR: So he had to like —

CR: And it was just like one chord. That's all. The same thing as a whole step down. Very easy to do.

MR: Are you glad that you learned to play the guitar and the mandolin and all that? Does it inform your singing?

CR: Well I won't say that I learned. I'm very self-taught on everything. But yeah, I mean all of that knowledge, as much as I have instrumentally, informs what I want to hear around me. It informs me what I can ask musicians to play in certain instances. You know, I'd like this, you know, "How about a single note here instead of the whole chord, how about" — so that we can discuss what we like and mutually come up with something. So it helps me to also, like at one point, I think it was the second album. I was able to, you know Larry Campbell, who produced that album is a multi-instrumentalist obviously, and I was able to guide him in a violin line that I wanted him to play you know. And different things, like if I want a harmony horns, maybe two horns on something, and I haven't written it out because I don't write for horns. That's another thing I have to go back to school for arranging someday, I don't know when I'm going to do that. But I'm able to know what I want, what sound I want. You know? So yeah, it all helps. Cause it's hard for me to learn, if I'm learning a part, so this goes back to back-up singing. If I'm learning a part I have to hear the whole chord. You can't show me something isolated. I have to know where it is in the chord. You know. So I have to hear the whole totality of everything.

MR: Yeah. So you can find out where you fit.

CR: Yeah.

MR: Well you've played hundreds, thousands of gigs maybe.

CR: Probably.

MR: Who can count? Does anything stand out in your mind about one of the best and perhaps one of the worst?

CR: One of the best, lately, I mean one of the best was singing behind Al Green. That was really fun I've got to say, I think it was on the David Letterman show. We were very excited about that. That was great. So I actually have, he signed a — I brought a vinyl cover for him to sign. So that was fun. I would say I got to sing with Elvis Costello once

which was a lot of fun. That might have been on the Letterman show as well with Toshi Reagon and BIGLovely, that was a while ago. And so there are a lot of them. I mean singing with David Bowie, that was really fun so there were a lot of highlights there. Singing at the Grammy Legends last year, was that last year? I was honoring the A&R man Ralph Peer and I sang Mamie Smith's "Crazy Blues." That was really fun.

MR: Oh the first one.

CR: With Shirley Caesar, like sitting, the great Shirley Caesar sitting right in front of me. And I didn't get nervous. That was really fun. And singing at the White House. So I got to sing with James Taylor's back-up singers — Kate Markowitz and Arnold McCuller.

MR: For the Obamas.

CR: For the Obamas. So I'm in a picture with the Obamas with the band. So that was a big highlight. And you know, there are a lot of highlights. I mean Steely Dan, I love working with them. I love, you know, the first time, we've done Rochester Jazz Festival with my band several times. And the first time that people waited on-line to come to a gig of mine, that was like a highlight, I thought people are here, we don't play for two hours. Really? So that was kind of, just the realization that people were actually coming to hear me was — . I'd say one of the worst — so there are a lot of bests you know. I'm fortunate. You know I shared the stage with Jimmy Heath a few years ago for the NEA Jazz Masters, and Poncho Sanchez on percussion and I mean it was like a great band. And it was like how do I get to stand on stage and sing with Jimmy Heath? That was amazing. And so I would say one of the worst was I used to do, when I was doing weddings, and there's a place called Leonard's of Great Neck and musicians will know about this. And so I was working for a wedding office that was booking me. And they had two bands. There's an upstairs and a downstairs room. So we're in the upstairs room and there's another band in the downstairs room. And the vocalist for that band couldn't make the gig for some reason. So they said to me, "Okay so you'll sing upstairs and then when you take a break upstairs you'll go downstairs and sing with this band. And then if they call you Susie you just say yes." Because all they wanted was a black singer. They don't care who it is. They just want somebody to sing whatever it was you know. So that was, I would have to say, okay, at that point I thought I don't care how much money I don't have I've got a find a way not to do this anymore. I just can't do it anymore. Because I was doing them, three a weekend for twelve years or something like that. Friday, two on Saturday, one again, three or four a weekend. So I just though, you know, and it was paying my bills.

MR: They would pair you with a band and you were supposed to know a certain repertoire?

CR: Well yeah but I was basically with one band. And they were really fun I mean at that point. Because they weren't like a top 40 band. I didn't know any of the top 40. They were basically a standards, jazz standards and Motown and then some soul stuff. So I

knew that stuff. But they were fun people to be with. And actually John Herrington, who plays with Steely Dan was also in that band. That's where I met him. So we were fun. But some of the other bands, you know they were very good musicians — but some of the other bands, the musicians, the level of musicianship was all over the place, or they could play one type of music and not the other. This band could play all styles. They could play jazz, they could play soul music, they could do everything. But I didn't find a lot of bands that could do everything. So there was another gig where this was a society orchestra where you, it was a big band, and they'd have specialty acts. So they'd have like a rock guitar player, a rock guitar player who would do that part of it. And then they'd have me, who would sing all the black songs, then they'd have a white woman, who would sing all the other, Carole King and all that other stuff. And so you'd sit for two hours and then you'd get up and sing your part of the thing and sit back down and that was it. You couldn't go anywhere, you couldn't do — and then they'd book these gigs like give me like western New York, the next place I'm going is Canada. The town that's in the western part of New York, and we're in New York City. They would book a gig up there and no hotel rooms. So you would drive seven hours or whatever, to wherever that was, do the gig and then don't even bring a toothbrush because you're not staying over. So, and this was also got me to drive. Because I didn't drive back then and this made me get my license. I said, "I am not riding with anybody." So I'd ride with these guys, and I had all these gigs, and I'm trying to make the rent you know. And I said, "You know I just need to sleep." "Oh you'll sleep, don't worry about it." So there were like five people in this little car, and they listened to Muzak. Do you remember Muzak?

MR: Indeed.

CR: So they listened to Muzak. Who listens to Muzak as the thing?

MR: An elevator.

CR: So they played Muzak the ride up and the whole ride back. And I thought this is the Twilight Zone. I can't sleep, I'm like this. And I'm five feet tall, I'm probably shorter now, but I'm sitting in this little car for seven hours to go and play with a society band of people that are not happy about life. They're just not happy. They get there and they're just not happy. And I said, "Okay, that's it." I have two hundred dollars to my name and I can't do this anymore. So I stopped.

MR: That's some motivation right there boy.

CR: But you know it builds character, right? What are you going to do?

MR: Dues paying.

CR: Dues paying.

MR: Wow. We had, last night at dinner we were talking a little bit about the jazz party scene. And I had observed over thee years that there were very few black musicians that seemed to be playing those things. And of course the audience was almost always all white.

CR: Yup.

MR: Do you have an observation about why that is?

CR: Well the only — I've done one. I did one jazz party. There's a big — I don't know what the word is, but there's a big gap between traditional jazz and modern jazz. And most people in the traditional scene are white from what I can gather. And so, and then the modern jazz scene, or I won't even say that, the bebop scene forward is a lot more mixed culturally. And I wonder why that is. I wonder why, because I certainly love swing and blues and Louis Armstrong and knowing where Bird and Diz came from and learning all that stuff. But you know I think it's cultural really more so, you know, people, you know, I think that we, you know black folks probably want to feel like the way bebop came along, that we want to be listened to, not danced to, because I did my first swing dance, and this was not a jazz party but I love doing swing dances as well. And I did my first swing dance with Earl May with the great bass player Earl May. And Eddie Locke was on drums. And Eddie hated playing for dancers.

MR: No kidding.

CR: Hated it. So I think it's a thing. I think it's just a thing of I want to stretch out and solo and I don't care if you dance. I want you to listen. So it may be that. It may just be that. And you know they don't really teach tunes in school. That's not a thing in a lot of schools. People don't know tunes too much.

MR: I don't know what they think they're going to do. They're going to go out and play modes?

CR: Yeah. They're going to play original music, you know, and kind of mood music and stuff like that, and they get to solo, you know, long solos. So that's kind of what I experience. And you know when I mention it to them, like "I'm in the Mood for Love" to some people they think it's corny. They just think of Little Rascals or whatever.

MR: Oh yes.

CR: Not Spanky.

MR: It was Sylvester? No. The guy with the top.

CR: With the, yeah. And so it's interesting. It's very interesting because I also have taught at the New York Hot Jazz Camp, which is going into its fourth year next year I believe. And I'm, besides Vincent Gardner, who plays with the Jazz at Lincoln Center Orchestra, Wycliffe Gordon came and spoke, you know, at one of them. But Vincent taught. And we were the only two black people involved, and I think I'm right about that.

MR: Including the students.

CR: Yeah. There were two Asian students, and there were a few singers of color. I had a few black student singers. But other than that I looked around last year, this year, and I thought yeah, hmm, and then Evan Christopher was involved too so I'm wrong about that. But there are a very smattering of us, just a smattering.

MR: Well hip hop carries more weight than bebop.

CR: Yeah it seems, these days. You know and then also people see, I don't know, it's just very interesting. I think people don't see a future or bright lights and whatever in jazz. They think oh jazz is for old people or something. But then, that's only in America. When we travel I have young audiences, mixed everything, people are dancing, they're having a good time, they're — so in the states it's tough. It's really tough.

MR: Are you an optimist generally?

CR: I say I'm a realist. I don't know about optimist. You know I don't think things are great or bad I just think they are what they are. And what are you going to do about it you know. You do the best you can do within the circumstances. And I try to just be a nice person and treat other people well and hope to be around people that feel that way or whatever. You know. And I like to feel good. I like to have fun you know, in the midst of everything that's going on around us. Because you know I think the world's always been a mess. So it is what it is.

MR: Anything in particular that makes you angry? Either musically or —

CR: I don't like to get angry. That's not a nice — I don't like that emotion. But B.S. makes me angry. Somebody posing as something but they're not really that, or saying you're going to do something that you have no intention of doing, so that type of thing. Or verbal abuse. Just abuse. You know people just trying to get over on one another. I don't like that. My mother didn't like that. My mother was a big advocate of equal, you know, equal rights, equal pay, equal treatment of people. So that's how I grew up. So I like clear communication and taking responsibility for one's actions.

MR: Well said. I've enjoyed talking to you very much.

CR: I've enjoyed talking to you.

MR: I'm looking forward to your gig tonight.

CR: Yeah.

MR: And it's been very informative, and I'm an optimist about your future.

CR: Oh well thank you very much.

MR: Okay.

CR: Things are looking good though, in that realm. So I'm very grateful.

MR: Thanks a lot.

CR: Thank you.

MR: Okay.